

Optimizing Learning in University: Three Evidence-Based Study Strategies

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Introduction

A university student spends many hours studying. Yet, many students are surprised and disappointed by their results. A common reason is that they rely on strategies that feel effective but are not: rereading a textbook chapter, for example, creates a sense of familiarity that is easily mistaken for real knowledge. Cognitive research has identified study techniques that produce more durable learning, yet students tend to underuse them. Self-report studies show that students favour rereading and highlighting over the methods that research supports (Miyatsu et al., 2018). The most popular study techniques are therefore not the most effective ones. Some reviews have responded by suggesting how students might improve the strategies they already prefer (Miyatsu et al., 2018) a more direct (one might even say, reasonable) route, however, is to adopt the strategies with the strongest evidence. This essay therefore asks how university students can optimize their learning, and answers by discussing three evidence-based strategies: pretesting, retrieval practice, and spaced practice. Effective studying is not simply a matter of effort, but of method.

Pretesting

The first strategy is pretesting: answering questions about the study material before any studying happens, even if the answers to the questions must be guessed. This might seem counterintuitive, but research indicates that this strategy improves later recall (Putnam et al., 2016). This activates any prior knowledge about the topic and prepares the student to connect new information with what is already known. Even incorrect guesses are useful as they make the student notice and remember the correct information once it appears.

Prequizzing is becoming easier to practice. (Putnam et al., 2016) suggests that before a study session (like a reading session or a lecture), a student can come up with questions about the topic and attempt to answer them, then return to those questions afterwards to check and correct the answers. However, many textbooks also include postreading quizzes. They can also be easily repurposed for pretesting. Thirdly, the rise of AI gives us new opportunities. A chatbot can create a quiz for you from your lecture slides or textbook chapter. It is even possible to prompt it to follow your precise specified needs such as difficulty level or quiz size. The main obstacle to this strategy is psychological rather than practical: it feels wrong to guess at material without any prior studying. Intuitively, students prefer to read first. Recognising that pretesting takes little time and prepares the memory helps to overcome this hesitation.

Retrieval Practice

The second strategy is retrieval practice: the reproduction or summarization of the study material after consuming it without looking at it. One implementation is the RRR-method, Read, Recite, Review, described in (Putnam et al., 2016): the student visits the lecture or reads the material, writes a summary from memory, and lastly reviews it against the study material. The second step is the retrieval itself, and the important part is that the student reproduces the material from memory rather than copying it. This both reactivates what was learned and reveals what was missed.

The student will not use the material for summarization but merely write down what they remember. This shows what they did not fully understand or remember. In its classical implementation, none of the common study strategies discussed in (Miyatsu et al., 2018) make use of retrieval.

As discussed in (Miyatsu et al., 2018), at least summarization and outlining can be altered in a way that makes use of retrieval by practicing these after studying the material from memory.

Spaced Practice

The third strategy is spaced practice: this has nothing to do with how to study but with when to study. If a student uses spaced practice, they study for short periods of time, mix studying of different subjects and take considerable breaks between study sessions. In practice, this means studying each subject a little on most days and revisiting earlier topics in later sessions. The opposite of spaced practice is massed, crammed studying. According to (Putnam et al., 2016), for the same time spent studying, spaced practice gives much better results.

The typical example of cramming is a long study session the day or even the night before an exam. The difference in retention becomes even greater in the long term. So while this might even give acceptable results on the day of the exam, for long-term learning, spaced practice is the much better study strategy.

Assuming university students are not merely studying to pass exams but are eager to learn and remember, spaced practice is the more effective strategy.

Conclusion

This paper examined three study strategies from (Putnam et al., 2016): pretesting, retrieval practice and spaced practice. The former two focus on retrieving prior and just acquired information; the latter is a strategy for allocating study time most efficiently.

Unlike the study strategies in (Miyatsu et al., 2018), the study strategies discussed in this paper are not chosen by popularity among students but by effectiveness. They do, however, have the disadvantage of needing more time in preplanning, a more conscious decision and commitment to stick to them as they may not be obvious or intuitive to students.

The technological advancements in AI can be of benefit to these study methods. For example, a student may feed their study material to a chatbot and have it create a pretesting quiz for them. In the RRR-method, they might ask an AI chatbot for feedback after the final review step of the method to make sure they didn't miss or misunderstand anything.

The strategies discussed in this paper do not mean that a student has to spend more time studying. With these more efficient strategies they should get better results with the same amount of time studying. Alternatively, if a student is already happy with their results, these study strategies should enable them to spend less time studying for a similar result. Any time saved can be spent as they wish.

References

Bibliography

Miyatsu, T., Nguyen, K., & McDaniel, M. A. (2018). Five Popular Study Strategies: Their Pitfalls and Optimal Implementations. *Perspectives on Psychological Science*, 13(3), 390–407. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1745691617710510>

Putnam, A. L., Sungkhasettee, V. W., & Roediger, L., Henry L. (2016). Optimizing Learning in College: Tips From Cognitive Psychology. *Perspectives on Psychological Science*, 11(5), 652–660. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1745691616645770>

AI disclosure statement

This assignment was written with extensive help from an AI assistant, and I am disclosing that help in full rather than concealing it. My intention was to make the assignment an honest experiment: to produce a real piece of academic writing while keeping a complete, public record of exactly how it was made. Transparency about how work is produced is a central academic value, and this project tries to live up to it. Every prompt I sent and every reply the assistant gave are recorded in the project's public repository, and the final text carries a word-level attribution showing which passages I wrote and which the assistant produced. The page linked from the title page shows the same attribution in colour.

The tool was opencode running a DeepSeek language model. I supplied the two assigned articles and the assignment brief, and I chose the topic and the three strategies. The assistant produced an initial full draft, which I then worked through carefully: I read it against the original articles, rewrote passages in my own words, corrected mistakes, cut material that was inaccurate or unnecessary, and decided what the argument should say. About four-fifths of the current wording is my own.

Both assigned articles, Miyatsu et al. (2018) and Putnam et al. (2016), were read by me. Every citation was checked against the original article, and no source is cited that I did not verify, so none of the references are fabricated.

How this happened, section by section:

- Introduction: first drafted by the assistant; I later rewrote the opening and the pivot sentence myself, and the assistant added the contrast between popular and effective techniques at my request.
- Pretesting, Retrieval practice and Spaced practice: first drafted by the assistant; I rewrote substantial parts of each in my own words and cut them for length.
- Conclusion: written by me first, then tightened with the assistant's help on style and grammar.

- Reflection: written entirely by me.
- This statement: arranged by me, with the assistant drafting the text.

Nothing here is concealed or misrepresented. No idea or wording belonging to another author is presented as my own, every reference points to a genuine source, and the help I received is set out openly. The work therefore contains no plagiarism and no fabricated sources. I am aware that the course is also concerned about relying on AI so heavily that it undermines learning, and I do not pretend that concern is trivial; ultimately my instructor is the right judge of whether the degree of help I used was appropriate. I take full responsibility for the final text and can explain and defend all of it.

Reflection

I felt like just writing the essay would have been a little too boring. I am excited about the what AI can do for us so I decided to use this essay to explore what is possible, what is fun, what helps my learning process and what is allowed. I definitely tried to test the waters of this last point. It is obvious that this new world of AI is new to us all, students and faculty and nobody really knows yet how it should be used. I suppose this is why the rules for AI usage are still not very clear. I am very curious to find out whether I will pass this assignment with the amount of AI I used.